

Pahankanuwa Sermon #19

English Translation

Translated from Sinhala

Author: Ven. Katukurunde Nanananda Thero

(Pahankaṇuwa Sinhala Audio Dhamma Sermon No.)

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa

(Homage to the Blessed One, the Worthy One, the Fully Self-Enlightened One)

Pali Stanza:

*Gabbhameke uppajjanti, nirayaṃ pāpakammino; Saggam sugatino
yanti, parinibbanti anāsavā.*

From:

Verse 126 from the Pāpavagga (Chapter on Evil) of the Dhammapada

Dear Listeners,

Between kamma and rebirth, there exists a kind of circular relationship. A sentient being who obtains birth (*jāti*) as a turn of result (*vipāka*) submits to and is governed by that very momentum of kamma when accumulating kamma once again, and by acting accordingly, prolongs *saṃsāra*. It is only by relying on the power of the Dhamma that one can appease the force of kamma and escape from *saṃsāra*. The Teacher of the Three Worlds, the Buddha, explained to the world that however powerful the wheel of kamma (*kamma-cakka*) may be, in the end, the wheel of Dhamma (*Dhamma-cakka*) triumphs. Today, these meritorious devotees will get to hear certain facts relevant to this matter from both the verse we have chosen as our theme and its background story (*nidāna-kathā*).

It is said that an Arahant Thero residing in Jetavana monastery went for alms (*piṇḍapāta*) to the house of a certain jeweler for twelve long years. That jeweler and his wife, placing this venerable monk in the position of their own parents, attended to all his needs and made offerings in this manner. One day, when this venerable monk arrived at the jeweler's house, the jeweler was slicing meat. At that very moment, while this venerable monk was looking on, a messenger arrived from King Kosala carrying a gem, saying, “The King has ordered to clean, pierce, and send this gem back.” Since the jeweler was slicing meat, he took the

gem with his blood-stained hands, placed it on top of a box, and went to wash his hands. There was a pet crane kept in this house. Attracted by the smell of blood, this bird, thinking the gem was a piece of meat, swallowed it while the Thero was watching.

When the jeweler returned from inside the house and looked, the gem was missing. Then he asked his wife and children if they had taken the gem. After they said they had not taken it, he went inside the house and discussed with them: “Without a doubt, it must be this monk who took it.” His wife said, “Oh, do not say such a thing. For all this time, over twelve years, we have never seen any fault in this venerable monk.” But the jeweler did not listen to this. He came out and asked the Arahant, “Now, who took the gem that was here? Did you take it, Venerable Sir?” “No, I did not take it,” replied the monk. “No one else was here. It must have been you, Venerable Sir, who took it. Give me that gem,” he said.

The venerable monk was helpless. Then, the jeweler went inside the house again and discussed with his wife: “Undoubtedly, it is this monk himself who took it. I must torture him if necessary to find out.” “Oh, please do not do that! We will be destroyed if you do. It would be better for our entire family to become slaves to the King instead,” she said. Then the jeweler said, “Even if we all became slaves, it would not cover the value of this gem.” Persisting in his view, he went out and bound the head of the venerable monk with a cord. Having bound it, he tightened it using a wooden stick like a tourniquet. Gradually inflicting pain, he then asked him if he took the gem. As he tightened it more and more, blood began to flow from the venerable monk's nose and ears—and also from his mouth—and unable to bear the pain, the venerable monk collapsed to the ground. When the pet crane came near, drawn by the smell of blood, and prepared to drink the blood, the jeweler, in his intense rage towards the venerable monk, shouted, “What are you doing here?” and kicked the crane. The animal died on the spot and fell flat on its back. The venerable monk saw this. Seeing it, he said, “Lay devotee, please loosen this binding a little. Loosen it and see if that bird is dead.” “May you die just like it!” said the jeweler. Then the venerable monk understood that the animal was indeed dead. Thereupon he said, “Lay devotee, this bird swallowed the gem. I did not say so because it would cause the death of this animal. Even if I were to die, I would not have said it. But now that this animal is dead, I am telling you.”

Thereupon, when the jeweler slit open the bird's belly and looked, there was the gem. Instantly, a great sense of spiritual urgency (*saṃvega*) arose in him. He came and fell prostrate at the feet of the venerable monk, pleading, “Oh, please forgive me for what I have done out of ignorance.” Then the venerable monk said, “Lay devotee, this is neither your fault nor my fault. This is a flaw of *saṃsāra*, a flaw of *saṃsāra*, a fault of *saṃsāra*. Therefore, I forgive you.” Then the lay

devotee said, “Venerable Sir, if you forgive me, please accept alms at this house as before.” Then the monk replied, “No, lay devotee. I understand the disadvantage (*ādinava*) of this—this happened because of entering inside houses, of going under the roof of a house. This kind of thing. Therefore, as long as there is strength in my legs, I will walk for alms (*piṇḍapāta*)." Saying this, he undertook a *dhutaṅga* (ascetic practice) at that very moment, reciting a certain verse related to that *dhutaṅga* practice:

“Pavattati munino bhattaṃ,

thoka-thokaṃ kule kule,

piṇḍikāya carissāmi,

atthi jaṅghābalaṃ mama.”

“For the silent sage who goes on alms-round, rice is cooked little by little in various houses. As long as I still have strength in my legs, I will walk for alms.” He expressed it in this manner. Even though he said so, not long after, the venerable monk attained final passing away / extinguishment (Nibbāna*) due to the injuries he had sustained. Furthermore, it is said that after some time, the jeweler and his wife also passed away. After they had died in this manner, the *bhikkhus* asked the Buddha where the people involved in this incident were reborn. It was on that occasion that the Buddha uttered the verse we have chosen as our theme. Here it is said that the crane—perhaps because it was associated with the household—was reborn in the womb of the jeweler's wife. Then, when they had all died, the question arose; after her death, the jeweler's wife was reborn in a heavenly world. The jeweler was reborn in hell (*niraya*), because he had inflicted fatal torture upon an Arahant, leading to the venerable monk's final passing away. The verse revealing this very fact is what we have placed as our theme:

“Gabbhameke uppajjanti, nirayaṃ pāpakammino,

Saggaṃ sugatino yanti, parinibbanti anāsavā.”

“Some are born in a mother's womb; evil-doers are born in hell (*niraya*); those of good conduct, who tread the good path, go to heaven, born in the celestial world; the *anāsavā*—the taints-free ones, the Arahants who are freed from taints—attain final passing away.” This is all that is expressed in this verse. So this is the story. What this verse actually demonstrates is how various individuals obtain birth (*jāti*) according to their respective kamma. Now, as we usually do, let us try to extract the advice, Dhamma-teachings, and Dhamma principles that can be drawn from this story and this verse.

This story is indeed a very moving one, a story that evokes a sense of spiritual urgency (*saṃvega*). On one hand, it is a story about a jeweler who did not recognize the true gem. On the other hand, it is a story about an Arahant who, for twelve years, went to the very same house to undergo the kamma-result of a grave kamma he had committed in the past. Thus, this story is about a monk who had become intimately associated (the word *kulūpaga* is used here, meaning “intimately associated with a family”) with the jeweler's household, coming there for twelve years. Such was his close association. Yet, because of a suspicion that arose in a single moment, the jeweler acted in such a way as to subject the Arahant to severe torture and bring about his death. From this too, we can reflect on something. When this venerable monk arrived, the jeweler was slicing meat. Based on this, we can understand how extremely easy it is to transition from one blood-dripping task to another blood-dripping task. The jeweler's inclination to inflict such severe torture did not appear to him as something very grave. The gem was far greater to him. He did not understand the value of the *Saṅgha*. He failed to recognize the highly virtuous venerable monk, the Arahant, who had been visiting him for twelve years. The gem sent by the King was far more important to him. So, we can reflect on one aspect of it from that.

Next, at the same time, we understand that there was a certain grave kamma destined to ripen for this venerable monk. When we look at it, there is a series of dramatic events here. Often, when the results of kamma have to be experienced, even in modern times we see how a multitude of events align in a strange manner. Now, here, when the venerable monk arrived on that day, the jeweler was slicing meat. Then came this message from the King, the story of the gem. Then the pet crane was also there. All of these came together, and in the end, the Arahant suffered that fatal injury—or rather, had to attain final passing away—due to his own kamma. It was for this very reason, understanding this, that when the jeweler begged for forgiveness, the Arahant, while forgiving him in an extremely virtuous manner, said, “This is neither your fault, nor is it my fault; it is the fault of *saṃsāra* (*saṃsāra-dosa*)." The “fault of *saṃsāra*” means that one must experience the results of the kamma one has committed. Kamma-results must be paid off. That is the lesson we must draw from this. Along with that, the vast store of virtues of this venerable monk also becomes clear to us. What existed as a minor defect was, as mentioned before, being intimately associated (*kulūpaga*). The meaning within the term “close association” (*kulūpaga*)—now, in the lay world, close association is considered a good term. But for the *Saṅgha*, close association is a fault. Therefore, it was indeed because of this that the venerable monk, realizing his error and understanding the disadvantage (*ādinava*) of close association, resolved to go for alms, to go from house to house for alms.

In any case, we can see the noble qualities of this venerable monk. Even though he was in such fatal pain, he did not give evidence against the pet crane. Not out of fear of anyone, but because it would violate his precept. Knowing that it would result in the decay and death (*jarāmaraṇa*) of a living being, he did not offer evidence in that way. At the risk of his own life, out of compassion for that animal, he remained silent about the truth. There is a precious virtue there. Similarly, he did not harbor any ill-will (*dosa* / anger) toward the jeweler who tortured him. Such a valuable treasure of virtues is made clear through the life of that monk. Next, if we examine this even more mindfully, what we see through this is kamma and its result (*vipāka*). This is also what is expressed in the verse. Some are born in a mother's womb. Some, in that manner, in hell (*niraya*). Now, here, hell became the destiny of the jeweler. We can also see the difference between the two; of the two, because the wife had deep faith (*saddhā*), she did not condone his actions. Due to her faith in the venerable monk, she did not approve of what her husband was going to do. It is said that because of that abundance of virtue and the service she had rendered, she obtained birth (*jāti*) in a heavenly world. Next, as for the Arahant, we all know that whatever happens, his final passing away is what takes place. After that, there is no birth (*jāti*). But through this story, we can see the relationship between kamma and its result, or rather, between kamma and becoming (*bhava*) or rebirth.

This law of kamma is an astonishingly powerful cosmic order (*niyāma*), so powerful that not even Buddhas and Arahants can bypass it. It is a natural law operating in this world. Therefore, one must actually accept this *saṃsāric* truth and strive to live accordingly. During the time of the Buddha, there were various teachers who did not believe in kamma, who did not believe in the results of kamma. Even in modern times, there might be people with such opinions and views. Therefore, especially in these times, this is a matter we must repeatedly remind ourselves of during these Dhamma sermons. There are various ideologies in the world that do not care about this world or the next. But if we reflect according to the Dhamma of the Buddha, depending on our conduct, according to the good or bad nature of the kamma we perform, we will obtain another becoming (*bhava*) or birth (*jāti*). Whether we experience pleasure or suffering (*dukkha*) in that rebirth is decided by the wholesome (*kusala*) or unwholesome (*akusala*) nature of that kamma.

Thus, we must also contemplate this matter: in what way is the mind tempted to perform an evil action when we act? Now, we all know that there are three trainings (*sikkhā*) in this Dispensation: Virtue (*sīla*), Concentration (*samādhi*), and Wisdom (*paññā*). Let us reflect on what the ultimate purpose of these is. Now, when an action has to be performed at any given moment, that very present moment is of utmost importance because, as we said at the very

beginning, we carry certain habits from our *saṃsāric* past. Due to repeatedly performing the same kamma, there are times when a person who has done evil deeds is compelled to submit and act in the very same way again. These can be subdued only by being mindful of the present moment. To put it briefly, the reason why the Buddha declared, *‘‘Cetanāhaṃ bhikkhave kammaṃ vadāmi’’* (‘‘Intention, O monks, is what I call kamma’’), is because it is in that brief moment of intention (*cetanā*) that we can do something about the activity of this kamma. This is an extremely important thing—this present moment. What was done in the past is done. Its result (*vipāka*) will come. Even when that result arrives, if at the moment of its arrival our stance, our determination, is inclined toward a good direction, then at that moment we can act with clarity and understanding. We can act with responsibility. We can act in a way that directs our *saṃsāric* journey toward a good path. Now, seeing the very same event, the jeweler acted in one way. His wife acted in another way. The monk, the Arahant, acted in yet another way—in an extremely noble and sublime manner. It was a difficult situation. But such things can be triumphed over only if one is established in a firm stance. Only if one has cultivated a certain attitude beforehand. Meritorious friends, it is precisely for this purpose that there is such a thing called Virtue (*sīla*).

Now, some people say that this virtue, meditation, and other such practices are unnecessary. When we examine this deeply, what is actually taking place here? In our day-to-day lives, when various situations arise, we can make the right decision at that moment only if we possess a good stance, such as a strong determination or a resolution of virtue (*sīla*). A scattered mind is easily dragged into the kamma of others. That is something we must keep in mind. A person with a scattered mind, who has no stance and no wholesome attitude, is easily dragged into the kamma of others and goes to places like hell (*niraya*). Why? Because this society, this world, is a place where each individual operates according to the momentum of the kamma they have brought with them. When you look at it, this is exactly like a puppet show. To a Buddha, to an Arahant, to those who have attained higher psychic knowledges (*abhiññā*), this appears just like a puppet show. Various things happen in accordance with past kamma, according to those results. But in the face of those, if we control that brief moment of intention (*cetanā*), that present moment, then we have won. What helps us in this is Virtue (*sīla*). Even on this occasion, these meritorious devotees undertook a set of precepts (*sikkhāpada*). What is achieved by that? A certain command was given to the mind, to wisdom (*paññā*), to intellect. A determination was made: ‘‘I will protect this precept.’’ With that, one can act with a principle, keeping that principle in mind. These meritorious devotees may have heard of *sāmpaṭṭa-virati* (abstinence when opportunity arises) as one of the

benefits of virtue (*sīla*). When the moment to commit a wrong deed arrives, one receives the strength to abstain from it through the determination of virtue (*sīla*). “I have undertaken such a precept, haven't I? If I am to protect it, acting in this way is not right.” Thus, on one hand, virtue (*sīla*) helps us in such situations, preventing us from getting entangled in the kamma of others, and protecting us by prioritizing our noble practice. Even more, it assists at a higher level in what is called Concentration (*samādhi*). Concentration means the stilling of the mind. Making the mind concentrated means obtaining a certain tranquility. It means removing the scattered nature of the mind, which is called the hindrances (*nīvaraṇa-dhamma*). It is easy for a one-pointed mind to make a decision. It can make a wholesome decision. Likewise, for one who has reached a state like equanimity (*upekkhā*) in concentration, they can respond to the questions that arise in a way that fits their lifestyle even more highly, in accordance with the Dhamma.

Next, the level higher than that is Wisdom (*paññā*). Virtue, Concentration, Wisdom. It is this Wisdom (*paññā*) that is demonstrated and polished in the life of that Arahant Thero. Through that insight wisdom (*vipassanā-paññā*), or rather, the wisdom obtained through Path-knowledge (*magga-ñāṇa*), one receives a special strength to protect oneself when these situations of kamma occur. The highest state is found there. Guided by the equanimity (*upekkhā*) that exists in the minds of the Arahants, they are able to triumph over such situations. So that is what Virtue, Concentration, and Wisdom are. It is worth reminding those who present such false views (*micchā-diṭṭhi*) that these are practically helpful to us in our daily lives.

Now, to explain this so that we can understand it even more practically in our daily lives: let us assume that you, meritorious devotees, bought a new car—a vehicle. Somehow or other, you also learned to drive it to some extent. Even if you have practiced, if you take it out onto the road and drive while ignoring the vehicles driven by others and ignoring the rules of the road, where will you end up? Even if you barely escape with your life, you might have to go to court and pay compensation for damaging other people's vehicles. You will have to face a multitude of such troubles. Therefore, you must keep the rules of the road. Next, you must drive this vehicle not while drunk, but with good mindfulness and clear comprehension, with very clear thinking. You must also drive this vehicle with a certain concentration (*samādhi*). Furthermore, in sudden emergencies, such as when others are about to crash into your vehicle, you must also have developed the wisdom (*paññā*), the intelligence, to think quickly and act in an instant. Thus, even for something like driving a vehicle in daily life, a certain level of Virtue, Concentration, and Wisdom is required. Do not misunderstand this. I am not over-simplifying this profound Dhamma; I mentioned this merely as an

ordinary illustration. In daily life, it is by being established in a certain virtue that one goes onto the road. One must know the side of the road that belongs to oneself. It is just like what was said about the bad destination (*duggati*) and the good destination (*sugati*). If you steer your vehicle into the wrong lane, that is the end of it right there. It will plunge down a precipice and ultimately be destroyed. Likewise, you might crash into other vehicles and get into various conflicts. Such is the nature of a single second in this world.

What we have here is a society complicated by the kamma-momentums brought by each individual. It is not the society that appears on the surface. At any given moment, each individual behaves in ways we do not expect. It is like the puppet show mentioned earlier. Now, that jeweler who, for twelve long years, had placed himself in the position of a parent and attended to that monk, went to hell because of a grave kamma committed in a brief moment, which bound him to a deadly kamma (*ānantarika-kamma*) that blocked all his wholesome merits. We can realize that no matter how good or decent we may be, if we do not possess these virtues like Virtue, Concentration, and Wisdom within us, we will have to reap terrible consequences from an unwholesome act (*akusala*) committed in a single brief moment, just like what happened to the jeweler. This is the very essence of the Dhamma taught by the Buddha. Virtue, Concentration, and Wisdom mean: the initial step of taming body and speech, stilling the mind, and then, Wisdom means the correct understanding of the world and life—by properly comprehending the Three Characteristics of Impermanent (*Anicca*), suffering (*dukkha*), and Not-self (*Anattā*), one appeases all these kamma-momentums at various levels, and finally, through the wheel of Dhamma, breaks the wheel of kamma, triumphs over the wheel of kamma, and brings this *saṃsāric* journey to an end; this is what is called attaining Arahantship, when viewed from the perspective of wisdom and the Paths and Fruits (*magga-phala*).

Now, if we think further about this, the Buddha himself has declared a certain analysis concerning kamma. Since it is also relevant to this story, let us present it on this occasion. The Buddha presented various analyses of kamma on different occasions. In one place, he shows, “Monks, there are four kinds of kamma.” If we express them in simple terms, they are easy to understand:

1. There is dark kamma with dark results.
2. There is bright kamma with bright results.
3. There is dark-and-bright kamma with dark-and-bright results.
4. There is neither-dark-nor-bright kamma with neither-dark-nor-bright results.

In this way, four kinds of kamma are shown. The Buddha explains each one of them in the following manner.

“Dark kamma with dark results” refers especially to the five heinous deeds (*ānantarika-kamma*). These meritorious devotees may have heard of them: killing one's mother, killing one's father, killing an Arahant, drawing the blood of a Tathāgata with a malicious mind, and causing a schism in the *Saṅgha*. If one commits these five heinous deeds, one is definitely reborn in hell (*niraya*). Therefore, what is meant here by “dark kamma” is that if someone performs bodily, verbal, or mental actions of an oppressive nature, they obtain birth (*jāti*) in an oppressive place. Here, hell (*niraya*) is specifically referred to. It is purely full of suffering (*dukkha*). That is why it is dark. The kamma is dark, and the kamma-result is also dark. When one is born in such a place, it is said that oppressive contacts (*phassa*) contact that person. When we look at this, a wonderful phrasing is used. All of of this is done by the machinery of kamma. And due to those oppressive contacts (*phassa*), that person is caught in a multitude of absolute painful feelings (*vedanā*). It is in this way that the Blessed One demonstrates the meaning of the phrase, *Kammadāyādā sattā* (“Beings are heirs to their kamma”). By that statement, it is shown that to everyone, to every being, kamma is their inheritance. That is to say, if someone commits a dark kamma that brings dark results, they obtain birth (*jāti*) in places like hell (*niraya*). Once reborn, they must, in whatever way, experience contacts (*phassa*) that correspond to it—oppressive contacts that bring painful feelings (*vedanā*). That is dark kamma.

Next, “bright kamma that brings bright results.” What are those? They are explained—and demonstrated there—as the ten wholesome courses of action (*dasa-kusala-kamma*). Abstaining from the ten unwholesome actions: killing living beings, stealing, sexual misconduct; and regarding speech, which is relevant to the virtue (*sīla*) undertaken on this occasion: lying, slandering, harsh speech, and frivolous talk; next, abandoning the unwholesome states of covetousness, ill-will, and wrong view (*micchā-diṭṭhi*), and cultivating wholesome minds—this is what is called bright kamma. In that very same way, one who has performed bright kamma goes and obtains birth (*jāti*) in a place of absolute happiness, such as the Subhakiṇha Brahma world—speaking of the highest level there. Thus, by performing bright kamma, one is reborn in a place that brings bright results.

Next, “dark-and-bright kamma” refers to a mixture of those; that is, performing bad kamma of that kind, and at the same time, performing wholesome deeds (*kusala*) occasionally. The places where those who have acted in this mixed manner are reborn are mentioned as the human world, certain heavenly worlds,

and also certain lower realms where there is not pure suffering (*dukkha*), but occasionally some happiness as well—pleasant feelings (*vedanā*) that can be called happy. In that way, the Buddha shows the third category there. It is mixed: dark-and-bright kamma with dark-and-bright results.

Fourthly, he shows—and this is the deepest one—neither-dark-nor-bright kamma with neither-dark-nor-bright results. This is special. These are identified as those which help to destroy all kamma. That kamma—neither-dark-nor-bright kamma—helps to conquer all kamma. This is explained as follows: if someone, in accordance with the Dhamma, arouses an intention (*cetanā*) to abandon the dark kamma with dark results, to abandon the bright kamma with bright results, and to abandon the dark-and-bright kamma with dark-and-bright results—briefly, the intention aroused to destroy all kamma—that is what is known there as neither-dark-nor-bright kamma. That is to say, to identify it briefly, it is the Noble Eightfold Path, the Middle Way. It is the Middle Path (*majjhimā paṭipadā*) that leads to Nibbāna which the Buddha shows there.

In another place, this very same concept of the Eightfold Path is explained as the seven factors of enlightenment (*satta bojjhaṅga*). Whether one cultivates these enlightenment factors called the *satta bojjhaṅga*, or cultivates the Eightfold Path at a supramundane (*lokuttara*) level, what ultimately happens? One is able to escape from the entire wheel of kamma consisting of merit and demerit, wholesomeness and unwholesomeness, through four stages: Stream-entry (*Sotāpanna*), Once-returning (*Sakadāgāmi*), Non-returning (*Anāgāmi*), and Arahantship—which these meritorious devotees have heard of. To put it briefly, the power of the wheel of kamma is broken by destroying its cause. As for formations (*saṅkhāra*), in the Dhamma of Dependent Co-arising (*paṭicca-samuppāda*), it is said, “*avijjā-paccayā saṅkhārā*” (“with ignorance as condition, formations arise”). It is due to ignorance (*avijjā*) that these formations (*saṅkhāra*) arise. The very word ‘kamma’ is expressed here in a subtle way as these formations (*saṅkhāra*). If we consider ignorance (*avijjā*), it is based on the notion of “I” and “mine” that all wholesomeness or unwholesomeness, merit or demerit, takes place. Therefore, if we are to eliminate them, we must eliminate that ignorance (*avijjā*). What helps us in this is the Middle Path, the Noble Eightfold Path. Or, from another perspective, the cultivation of the seven factors of enlightenment (*bojjhaṅga*): mindfulness (*sati*), investigation of states (*dhamma-vicaya*), energy (*viriya*), joy (*pīti*), tranquility (*passaddhi*), concentration (*samādhi*), and equanimity (*upekkhā*). That is the special message that a Buddha gives to the world. There are various opinions among different teachers in the world regarding whether a Buddha is born or not. Only a Buddha declares the path that can break this cycle.

That is why the fourth category mentioned here is of paramount importance: neither-dark-nor-bright kamma with neither-dark-nor-bright results. It conquers both wholesomeness and unwholesomeness.

Now, when this is said, some people might misunderstand it. They might think: “In that case, meritorious deeds are not necessary. We do not need to think about wholesomeness or unwholesomeness.” But one cannot escape like that. This is an extremely subtle point. Many people get confused here too. That is why, when declaring the Dhamma, the Buddha reminded us that some people grasp wrong views (*micchā-diṭṭhi*) as if they were grasping a snake by its tail. What we have here is a middle way. There is a certain sutta discourse where the Buddha has presented this middle way most beautifully. On one occasion, a certain deity came and asked the Buddha, “Venerable Sir, how did you cross over the flood?” By “flood,” the deity used a term that these meritorious devotees might have heard of in Dhamma analyses: the word *ogha* (flood). There are four such floods that sweep beings away in *saṃsāra*: the flood of sensuality (*kāmogha*), the flood of becoming / existence (*bhavogha*), the flood of views (*diṭṭhogha*), and the flood of ignorance (*avijjāgha*). That is to say, sensual thoughts flow like a great torrent and sweep beings away. Next, the desire for existence in becoming (*bhava*), craving for becoming (*bhava*)—craving (*taṇhā*) for becoming (*bhava*). Beings get caught in various views and are swept away. Lastly, ignorance (*avijjā*)—unknowing. All of these are shown as floods—the four *saṃsāric* floods that sweep beings away.

While being swept away by these four floods, the deity asked the Buddha how he crossed over them. The Buddha gave an extremely brief answer: “Friend, I crossed over the flood by not halting and by not straining.” “By not halting, and by not straining, I crossed over the flood,” he replied. When asked for further details on how that was, he said, “Friend, when I halted, I sank; when I strained, I was swept away. Therefore, it was by not halting and by not straining that I crossed over the flood.” This, meritorious friends, is that middle path. Now, think of a situation where one is being swept toward a sluice gate, or caught in a whirlpool. If you just let yourself go, one of those things will happen. If you struggle frantically without trying to escape in the proper way, you will still be swept away. You either go under, or you get carried away. Such is the situation regarding this kamma. That is to say, regarding these questions about kamma, one must look at it this way: those unwholesome evil deeds indeed yield results for the *saṃsāric* being. We cannot say they do not exist. Therefore, they must be conquered through wholesome deeds (*kusala*). This is the middle path. In place of the unwholesome (*akusala*), the wholesome (*kusala*) must be cultivated. In place of demerit, merit must be made. By doing so, one must arrive

at a certain firm stance. A certain concentration (*samādhi*)—briefly, a concentrated mind—can be obtained only if one protects those virtues like Virtue (*sīla*). What is found in virtues like Virtue (*sīla*) is precisely this: distinguishing and understanding wholesome and unwholesome, understanding merit and demerit, and treading that path of wholesomeness. Therefore, these cannot be cast aside. If one breaks, shatters, and destroys the raft before crossing over, there is no crossing over for that person.

Therefore, what is called the middle path here involves neither halting nor going to one extreme. If one does that, one might go to that extreme called *kāmasukhallikānuyoga* (indulgence in sensual pleasures), thinking, “We can live however we want and enjoy ourselves.” Otherwise, if one goes to the opposite side, one begins to strain frantically, like *attakilamathānuyoga* (self-mortification). There are people who go to such an extreme that, like the Nigaṇṭhas (Jains) who believed all knots must be untied, they even untie the knots of their clothes and go naked. Those are the two extremes that the Buddha has pointed out. Halting is *kāmasukhallikānuyoga*—indulging in the five cords of sensual pleasure as one pleases, without any regard for wholesomeness, unwholesomeness, or virtues. The other extreme is... these meritorious devotees may have heard of those who lived in the past, close to the practice of the Nigaṇṭhas, living like dogs (canine vow) or living like cattle (bovine vow). Undertaking various vows, they believed they would find liberation through them. Those who live by adopting various such false views and vows of virtue (*sīlabbata*) are at that other extreme. Instead of those, what the Buddha points out is that, with the help of Virtue (*sīla*), one cultivates Concentration (*samādhi*). Without halting there either, with the help of Concentration, one next mindfully sees the Three Characteristics of Impermanent (*Anicca*), suffering (*dukkha*), and Not-self (*Anattā*), thereby raising Wisdom (*paññā*). Meritorious friends, to raise Wisdom simply means the destruction of that ignorance (*avijjā*). If indeed it is because of ignorance (*avijjā*) that all these formations (*saṅkhāra*), regarded as wholesome and unwholesome, arise in this mind-stream, then the path to the stilling of those formations (*saṅkhāra*) is actually the special message that the Buddha introduced to the world. That is why this path is called the path of stilling these formations (*saṅkhāra*).

Now, there are two aspects to what is called Right View (*sammā-diṭṭhi*). Many people speak about it without proper understanding. One aspect of this Right View is *kammaṣassakātā sammā-diṭṭhi* (Right View of the ownership of kamma). Standing on that firm ground that “kamma is one's own,” one acts in a way that allows them to face it. Therefore, one must live with a correct

understanding of merit and demerit, wholesomeness and unwholesomeness, living with eyes wide open. Why? Because otherwise, one will fall into those terrible bad destinations (*duggati*) and *saṃsāra* will be prolonged, and one will become unable to raise one's head again. That is why it is called *kammasassakatā*—the feeling that “it is mine.” Why is it said that “kamma is one's own”? One cannot escape by simply saying “there is no self/person.” Because it is with the feeling of “I” that those actions are committed. Its result (*vipāka*) will definitely come. And the turn of its result also comes based on that very “I”. It is like a kind of “responsibility.” Responsibility is something one has taken upon oneself. It is by taking responsibility as “I” that a person engages in those evil deeds. Correspondingly, that kamma flows back to that person. That is why kamma is said to be “one's own,” “one's kinsman, one's refuge.” One must not misunderstand by bringing Not-self (*Anattā*) close to this level. That is one level. To put it briefly, that is the side of arising (*samudaya-pakkha*) of the *saṃsāric* being. Now, there are two things: arising and ceasing. Out of these, the *saṃsāric* being is always on the side of arising (*samudaya*). Arising means coming into being. They are always trying to produce, to acquire, to renew. The entire *saṃsāric* existence, instead of acknowledging impermanence—forgetting impermanence—is an effort to create the notion that the world is permanent. The perception of permanence (*nicca-saññā*). What must be done to generate the feeling that the world is permanent? One must forget that these things are decaying and passing away, and instead, by renewing them, bring up the notion that “each of these is eternal.” The sense of “I-ness” also runs on that. Consequently, one is bound to experience the results of the kamma performed accordingly. That is inevitable.

Thus, the other side is the supramundane (*lokuttara*) side. What is that side? That side looks toward cessation (*nirodha*). The noble disciple (*ariya-sāvaka*) faces the side of cessation (*nirodha*). The ordinary worldling (*puthujjana*), on the other hand, faces the side of arising (*samudaya*). To put it another way, no matter how much suffering (*dukkha*) they experience today, everyone is living as if they think: “Tomorrow morning will be better.” Even if this life is spent, they wish for another life: “I could not fulfill my hopes in this life, but in the next life I will be able to.” *Saṃsāra* is precisely this kind of journey driven by ignorance (*avijjā*) and craving (*taṇhā*). That is living on the side of arising (*samudaya*). The law of kamma affects such a person. Therefore, one must accept it and try to live according to it. Otherwise, one will have to experience results in a much more dangerous state. Next, escaping from this—the way to escape is not by committing extreme attempts like those Nigaṇṭhas, who subjected their bodies to various tortures, thinking, “I will wear out past kamma

by this suffering, and I will perform no more kamma,” wearing muzzles, or even discarding their clothes and acting in that manner.

The Buddha has shown that these momentums of kamma can be appeased only through Wisdom (*paññā*), only by destroying ignorance (*avijjā*). It cannot be done by other methods. Nor can all this kamma be completely worn out by experiencing it. This destruction of kamma is said to be accomplished by that fourth, neither-dark-nor-bright kamma mentioned here. The “destruction of kamma” is like... now, these meritorious devotees have heard that a person [a Stream-enterer] is reborn at most seven times. How does that happen? Based on the power obtained through that Path-knowledge of Stream-entry (*Sotāpatti-magga-ñāṇa*), due to the force of the defilements (*kilesa*) cut off by it, and by that power, the person who has become a Stream-enterer becomes incapable of performing kamma that could lead to the lower realms (*apāya*). Rebirth in the lower realms is caused by kamma performed with view of existing group/body (*Sakkāya-diṭṭhi*). Now, view of existing group/body (*Sakkāya-diṭṭhi*) is the most gross, coarse aspect of the notions of “I” and “mine.” That layer of ignorance (*avijjā*) is shattered by Path-knowledge (*magga-ñāṇa*). That is why that person cannot go to the lower realms. To put it briefly, they are freed from the lower realms. Next, as a direct result of the reduction of that sense of “I-ness,” their rebirths are limited to at most seven times. In that way, the Buddha solves this problem. This is the middle path. That is why it was said, “by not halting and by not straining.” These questions are solved through Wisdom (*paññā*), not through other artificial methods. For, the wheel of kamma in this *saṃsāra* is that dangerous. Even to Arahants and Buddhas, this kamma yields results. But that is only regarding the body they have brought with them; even those noble ones whom we call Arahants and Buddhas arose in this world due to a certain force of kamma. Correspondingly, they have to experience those results. But it ends right there. After that, they do not obtain birth (*jāti*) again. It is to solve that problem that the Buddha has pointed out the Paths and Fruits (*magga-phala*). That is: Stream-entry with at most seven rebirths; next, Once-returning, coming back to this world only once; then, Non-returning, being born in the Brahma world, staying there for a certain period, and attaining Arahantship and final passing away. Those Arahants, Buddhas, and Paccekabuddhas who attained it in this very world do not obtain birth (*jāti*) again. Saying “they do not obtain rebirth again” means that they have destroyed that accumulated mass of kamma.

So that is the solution presented by the Buddha. We must contemplate these matters with wisdom and understand them. Otherwise, those wrong views (*micchā-diṭṭhi*) mentioned will arise—that is, “*saṃsāra* grows through both merit and demerit; through both merit and demerit, or rather, through every

wholesome and unwholesome deed, *saṃsāra* is prolonged.” “Therefore, we do not need to be keen on merit. As for demerit—there is no question about it anyway. It happens naturally. But the difficult thing is making merit and doing wholesome deeds; we do not need to trouble ourselves about them. If we do, *saṃsāra* will be prolonged.” Look, that is a wrong grasp. It is like grasping the snake by its tail. The Buddha has shown the way it should be done. As mentioned earlier, through Virtue (*sīla*), one tames body and speech at a practical level. What is the result obtained from that? It is the blameless happiness (*anavajja-sukha*), the absence of remorse. With the help of that, one next cultivates Concentration (*samādhi*). One does not linger in that Concentration either. That, too, is something that prolongs becoming (*bhava*). The Buddha does not grasp onto that either. Instead, with the help of Concentration, using that stilled, one-pointed mind, one sees through the Three Characteristics. The special vision that a Buddha presents to the world is Insight (*vipassanā*): the Three Characteristics of Impermanent (*Anicca*), suffering (*dukkha*), and Not-self (*Anattā*). That too can be understood through insight if there is a good concentration. It is through that level of insight, after insight has been significantly developed, and through the penetration of the Paths and Fruits (*magga-phala*), through that seeing through, that one understands: “There is no entity called ‘I’. There is nothing here to grasp as ‘I-ness’.” Once that understanding is attained, or rather, once the Dhamma of Dependent Co-arising (*paṭicca-samuppāda*) is fully understood, then from that person, no unwholesome or wholesome deeds driven by that view of existing group/body (*Sakkāya-diṭṭhi*) are performed. That is the solution the Buddha points out.

Here we have placed as our theme a verse that speaks briefly about becoming (*bhava*). But we must realize that this *saṃsāric* being obtains various rebirths based on that distinction between wholesomeness and unwholesomeness, based on merit and demerit. It is an eternal natural law (*dhamma-tā*). Furthermore, one is easily tempted precisely toward those evil deeds. Because one is easily tempted, we must establish a certain stance, we must make a firm determination. Otherwise, one will automatically be dragged into them. One will be dragged into the kamma of others. By being dragged in that way, one will have to suffer in terrible realms like the lower worlds (*apāya*). Therefore, a certain level of Virtue (*sīla*) is necessary. Even in Virtue, a virtue cultivated over a long period is much stronger. A virtue practiced for a short time has less strength. That is why you, meritorious devotees, say you “undertake precepts” (*sīla*), or rather, say you “protect the Five Precepts (*pañcasīla*)” that belong to you. Undertaking them, you make a determination. Having determined, you reflect upon them. Having reflected, when the time comes to face situations that challenge them, you bring forward the mental factor of abstinence (*virati-cetasika*) as *sampatta-

virati* (abstinence when opportunity arises) to avoid the situation. The mind of detachment. That mind of detachment is extremely helpful to escape from such dangerous situations. Next, it is through the strength built by that Virtue (*sīla*) that one is able to develop Concentration (*samādhi*).

When you contemplate in this manner, these meritorious devotees will be able to understand the true meaning of the middle path pointed out by the Buddha. Next, through all of this, we must contemplate the nature of these formations (*saṅkhāra*). This existence created by the very mind called formations (*saṅkhāra*)—correspondingly, those worlds exist. The Buddha has shown that sometimes separate worlds arise accordingly. It is said that at the end of an aeon (*kappa*), separate Brahma mansions arise for certain individuals. From this, we can see how powerful this mind is—this accumulation of kamma performed by our mind. And underlying this is that very ignorance (*avijjā*) mentioned earlier. Like a darkness, that ignorance (*avijjā*), by creating the delusion of “I” and “mine” due to its dark nature, tempts the world into this kind of activity. If one is to escape from it, one must gradually, in the manner mentioned, utilize these—Virtue, Concentration, and Wisdom—neither casting them aside nor clinging to them, but with a balanced attitude. In certain places, this is compared to a journey by seven chariots. In those days, unlike today, if there was an urgent journey, several horse chariots were stationed at various points. One travels in one chariot and gets into the next when the horses of the first get tired. From that, one gets into another. Changing through seven horse chariots in this manner, the simile is given of King Pasenadi of Kosala traveling in an emergency from Sāvattī to Sāketa. In that very same way, the Buddha has shown each stage of purification (*visuddhi*) here. With the help of Virtue (*sīla*), one develops purification of mind (*citta-visuddhi*). With the help of purification of mind, one develops purification of view (*diṭṭhi-visuddhi*). Passing through a sequence of seven stages of purification in this manner, one is finally able to attain the states of the Paths and Fruits (*magga-phala*).

From this, we can reflect on how wonderful the middle path shown by the Buddha is. The ordinary world cannot find a way to escape from this *saṃsāra*. Why? Because they either sink by halting, or they are swept away by straining in this torrent. Now, through every kamma we perform, there is a portion that sinks down into the mind-stream (*citta-santāna*). In this Dhamma, the portion that sinks into the mind-stream is called underlying tendency (*Anusaya*). Just as a heavy object sinks to the bottom, during our long journey in *saṃsāra*, there is a portion that comes and deposits itself in our mind-stream as underlying tendency (*Anusaya*). Similarly, there is something called *āśava* (cankers / taints / influxes). *Āśava* means that which flows, carrying the idea of an influx. Next, there is another portion that sweeps beings away, which is called *ogha* (flood)—

what we have been referring to as the torrents. What are these? They are *saṃsāric* habits. Through every kamma we perform, a habit is formed. That is why we referred to it earlier as a wheel—the wheel of kamma. To put it briefly, in the Dhamma, this is sometimes shown as the round of kamma (*kamma-vaṭṭa*), the round of result (*vipāka-vaṭṭa*), and the round of defilements (*kilesa-vaṭṭa*). This word *vaṭṭa* (round) is frequently used. *Vaṭṭa* means going in a circle, or rather, a wheel. How does each of these turn into a wheel? They become habits. Breaking those *saṃsāric* habits is not easy. It can be broken only through Wisdom (*paññā*). Those habits accumulate. When one performs a single kamma—just as we said about the jeweler who was slicing meat, it became extremely easy for him to transition to another blood-stained kamma. In that manner, each kamma we perform assists another as a habit, whether it is good or bad. Thus proceeding, the portion that simultaneously sinks into the mind-stream is what is called the underlying tendency (*Anusaya*). Those cannot be easily removed. Similarly, the taints (*āśava*) are the portion that flows in. Therefore, meritorious friends, a mind that removes those sinking portions called underlying tendency (*Anusaya*), taints (*āśava*), and floods (*ogha*); that destroys those flowing taint-forces called sensuality, becoming (*bhava*), views, and so on; and next, that possesses the strength to escape from those torrents called floods (*ogha*)—such a mind is called the mind of an Arahant, the mind of a Buddha. It is for this purpose that a Buddhist fulfills all the practices. It is not for some minor thing as the ordinary world thinks. It is not merely to protect some social ethics. It is not just for the small purpose of maintaining society well. There is a much deeper meaning. One's *saṃsāric* liberation belongs to oneself. When it is said, *‘‘kammadāyāda’’* (heir to kamma), one must take responsibility for the store of kamma one has brought along. One must take responsibility for the store of kamma one performs in this *saṃsāra*. The path to escape from it was ultimately declared by the Buddha as that neither-dark-nor-bright kamma. That is, the cultivation of the Noble Eightfold Path.

The actions performed with a general understanding of good and bad while looking toward the side of arising (*samudaya*) are called *‘‘sāsavā puññabhāgiyā upadhivepakkā’’* (accompanied by taints, siding with merit, ripening in assets). They are accompanied by taints (*āśava*). That is accepted. Accompanied by taints, accumulating assets (*upadhi*) on the side of merit—assets meaning those which provide various *saṃsāric* becoming (*bhava*), enjoyments, and wealth. There is that kind of Right View. Similarly, what is the deep Right View (*sammā-diṭṭhi*)? It is the Right View regarding the Four Noble Truths: ‘‘This entire existence is suffering (*dukkha*). craving (*taṇhā*) is its cause. The calming of this craving (*taṇhā*) is Nibbāna. The path to it is the Noble Eightfold Path.’’ It is this understanding of the Four Noble Truths that is

called Supramundane Right View (*lokuttara sammā-diṭṭhi*). Thus, the understanding of good and bad of beings at a mundane or *saṃsāric* level is that lower-level view. That is what is called *kammaśassakatā sammā-diṭṭhi*—the understanding of merit and demerit, good and bad. Everything is not accomplished by that alone. Standing on that, having fulfilled those requirements, ultimately the final goal must be the deep realization of the Four Noble Truths. Saying “the entire existence is suffering (*dukkha*)” means that there is no “self” (*attā*) or “I” here. The method of treading toward that realization is what the Buddha has pointed out in the deep aspect of the Noble Eightfold Path. In a supramundane mind, all these eight factors arise together. Ordinary people, when cultivating the Noble Eightfold Path, take each factor separately and develop them in a piecemeal manner. But it is in the meditative mind that the Noble Eightfold Path arises supramundanelly. It is said that all eight factors arise simultaneously in a single mind. That means all eight factors have become straight. Now let us imagine: those eight factors are crooked. The eight factors are crooked in various ways. At the very moment when all eight factors, from Right View (*sammā-diṭṭhi*) to Right Concentration (*sammā-samādhi*), become straight, that is when the realization of the Paths and Fruits (*magga-phala*) takes place—viewed from the deepest sense. Therefore, there is a profound depth to the supramundane compared to the way ordinary people cultivate Right View (*sammā-diṭṭhi*), Right Intention (*sammā-saṅkappa*), and so on.

Therefore, through this, these meritorious devotees must contemplate: we have raised many points that go deeper and deeper concerning kamma and becoming (*bhava*) or rebirth, drawing from this story and verse. On this valuable day, bringing what has been gathered close to your own lives, without neglecting these qualities like Virtue (*sīla*), through them—through the restraint thus cultivated—next developing Concentration (*samādhi*), and through that Concentration, obtaining that insight wisdom (*vipassanā-paññā*), you must resolve to escape from this dangerous *saṃsāra*. Make a wish that the store of merit we accumulated today through this Dhamma preaching and Dhamma hearing, as well as all the mental strengths of faith (*saddhā*), energy (*viriya*), mindfulness (*sati*), concentration (*samādhi*), and wisdom (*paññā*) that these meritorious devotees developed through hearing the Dhamma at this moment, may definitely become a strong support (*upanissaya*) for crossing over the *saṃsāric* flood—for crossing over this torrential flood by not halting and by not straining.

Also, for this meritorious gathering, today is an occasion where our small hall has become a bit larger. For this too, these faithful lay devotees must have helped and

supported in various ways. Similarly, a seat has been offered as a Dhamma-seat (*dhammāsana*). Although we do not expect much, a Dhamma-seat has been offered out of respect for the Dhamma. Recalling that merit, all these meritorious devotees who have supported according to their capacity, and with the help of this store of merit accumulated especially through hearing the Dhamma, may all those states that obstruct one's journey to Nibbāna in this world be removed through the power of this merit! May supportive states be attained! With Dhamma-induced peace, having appeased those kamma-momentums, may this wholesome merit definitely become a supportive condition to finally conquer the entire wheel of kamma through the wheel of Dhamma, by the power of Dhamma! Make that aspiration. Likewise, may the Sasana-protecting deities and Brahma kings, as well as the departed relatives who have passed away in your respective names, and all beings from the Avīci hell up to the Akanitha heaven, rejoice in this merit of Dhamma preaching and Dhamma hearing! Having rejoiced, making the aspiration, “May they attain the supreme deathless Nibbāna through a preferred Bodhi as quickly as possible,” recite these verses and share the merit.

“*Ettāvatā ca amhehi.....*”